

Pepper Vadai (Baked Lower-Carb Version)

A crisp, peppery South Indian-style snack made with whole urad dal (black gram), warming spices, and an optional almond flour addition to reduce overall carbs and improve crunch. This version is baked instead of deep fried and stores well.

Why This Version Works

- Whole urad/black gram gives authentic flavor and texture
- Sprouting (optional) may improve digestibility and flavor depth
- Almond flour helps reduce net carbs and creates a lighter crisp texture
- Chia seeds help bind the dough naturally without rice flour
- Double baking method helps achieve better crispness without frying

Main Ingredients

- 1 cup whole urad dal / whole black gram (with skin)
- 1/2 cup almond flour (optional but recommended for lower-carb texture)
- 2 tbsp chia seeds
- 2 tbsp ghee
- Salt to taste

Spice Mix

- 2 tbsp whole black pepper
- 1 tbsp cumin seeds
- 1/4 tsp hing (asafoetida)

Optional Flavor Additions

- 8–10 curry leaves, finely chopped
- 1–2 green chilies
- 1 tbsp grated ginger
- Crushed fennel seeds for a different flavor profile

Preparation Steps

- Wash and soak the whole urad dal overnight (8–10 hours).
- Drain completely.
- Optional: sprout the dal for 12–24 hours for improved digestibility and lighter texture.
- Dry grind pepper, cumin, and hing into a coarse spice mix.
- Grind soaked dal with almond flour, chia seeds, salt, and spice mix using minimal water.
- The batter should remain thick and coarse.
- Mix in melted ghee and refrigerate for 30–60 minutes.

Shaping & Baking

- Preheat oven to 160°C / 320°F.
- Shape batter into small flattened vadai shapes.
- Bake 8–10 minutes.
- Flip carefully and bake another 8–10 minutes.
- Reduce temperature to 120°C / 250°F.
- Bake another 15–25 minutes until crisp.
- Cool completely before storing.

Storage Tips

- Store fully cooled vadai in an airtight container.
- Keeps 4–5 days at room temperature.
- Can be re-crisped in air fryer or oven.

Texture Tweaks

- For crispier vadai: flatten thinner and extend low-temp bake.
- For softer texture: grind smoother and skip second bake.
- If batter is wet: add almond flour or coconut flour.
- If batter is dry: add water 1 tsp at a time.

Variations

- Air Fryer Version: 160°C for 12–15 min, then 120°C for 5–8 min.
- Mixed Seed Version: add sesame, pumpkin, or sunflower seeds.
- Herb Version: add curry leaves, cilantro, or dill.

- High Protein Version: add whey isolate or pea protein isolate.
- Traditional Version: skip almond flour and chia seeds.

Approximate Nutrition

- Per small vadai:
- Calories: ~70–90
- Protein: ~3–4g
- Net Carbs: ~3–5g
- Fat: ~5–6g

Serving Suggestions

- Serve with coconut chutney, yogurt, masala chai, or rasam.
- Works well as travel snack or crunchy tea-time savory bite.